The M-ZRT Guide to Joy Using Third-Person Video Games

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A Regime Theory of Joy, *ssrn*

Action coupling

Action coupling refers to the tendency for one action to automatically recruit another.

In everyday behavior, asking a question recruits an attempt to answer it, walking recruits movement toward a destination, noticing an object recruits identification.

Within the M-ZRT framework (The Minimal Z-Reduction Task), these couplings are viewed as contributors to a high-control behavioral regime. M-ZRT therefore includes brief perturbations that selectively weaken these links, thereby creating conditions that may facilitate access to joy.

Examples include asking a question without attempting to answer it, making a purposeless detour while walking, or shifting attention to an object without assigning it a role.

The goal is to reduce the automatic coupling between one action and its expected continuation.

Within the M-ZRT framework, the three intervention classes target different aspects of cognitive organization.

Suspension aims to interrupt automatic continuations.
Openness broadens the range of information that can remain present.
Salience perturbations increase or decrease the apparent significance of otherwise ordinary stimuli (see Appendix 1).

Normally:

1. A question naturally develops into an investigation.
2. Completing an action is often followed by checking whether it succeeded.
3. Looking at a visual obstacle naturally recruits imagining what lies behind it.

M-ZRT

1 Small Curiosity

A small curiosity arises toward an object, color, sound, or situation without becoming an investigation. The curiosity is allowed to exist without seeking an explanation or resolution. It is simply left unfinished and normal activity continues.

2 No Checking

After completing a simple action, do not immediately verify its outcome. For example, after placing an object on a table, resist the brief impulse to check whether it is exactly where intended. Continue directly with the next activity.

3 Closed Door

Look at a closed door, a corner, or another visual obstacle for a few seconds without imagining what might be behind it. Simply let the visible surface remain complete in itself, then continue normally.

We will now apply the M-ZRT framework to third-person video games and examine the logic behind exercises that are compatible with this context. Rather than presenting an arbitrary collection of techniques, the goal is to illustrate how the principles of suspension, openness, salience perturbation, and reduced action coupling can be translated into concrete in-game exercises.

Alter Your Path

Because movement is the primary activity in third-person video games, it naturally becomes tightly coupled to navigation and goal pursuit. While moving through the game world, briefly change direction for no apparent reason, then continue normally. The change should be short. Then resume exploring or playing.

No Meaningful Extraction

Because text frequently appears, it naturally recruits interpretation and decision-making. Whenever text appears, briefly read it without trying to extract its meaning. Let it remain as a sequence of words rather than information that must be understood. After a moment, continue playing normally.

Object Without Function

Because third-person video games are filled with objects that immediately suggest specific actions, perception naturally becomes coupled to action. Briefly observe an object as if it had no predefined function. Let it remain simply a visible object, without preparing or selecting an action. Then continue playing normally.

No Post-Action Check

Because third-person games constantly require small interactions, such as managing inventory, interacting with merchants, opening menus, or manipulating objects, completed actions are often followed by an automatic verification. Perform a simple action, then do not check its outcome afterward. Continue playing normally.

Corridor Without Prediction

Because third-person games are filled with corridors naturally invite anticipation of what comes next, movement is often guided by continuous mental simulation. Before choosing a corridor, briefly refrain from imagining what might be inside or where it leads, allowing the next action to occur without prior mental simulation, then continue normally.

Redistribute Salience

Because attention naturally becomes organized around elements that appear valuable, certain objects automatically stand out. Briefly let an ordinarily irrelevant element become as perceptually important as the naturally salient ones. For example, look at one arbitrary inventory slot, occupied or empty, as though it deserved special attention for a few seconds. Or, pick up a completely ordinary item (e.g. low-level potion) and treat it as if it were the most remarkable object in the inventory.

Interrupt the Thought

Because internal thought is itself a major source of planning, optimization, and action selection, mental sequences can become increasingly organized around predicting the next step. Whenever you notice yourself thinking about the game, the current situation, the exercise, or anything else, end the thought with a few unrelated, meaningless words, for example, "blue, car, sky." Then continue playing normally.

This last one prevents a developing thought from becoming a stable predictor of future actions by introducing a brief unrelated interruption.

Link to a video with in-game example: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Lonx5j-hvpM (Account: https://www.youtube.com/@FlorianMorin-j7n4i)

Florian Morin proposes that joy is gated by evaluative monitoring: joy does not simply fade, it becomes inaccessible when monitoring and optimization remain active.

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Appendix 1 Lowering Next-Action Pressure With 3 Types of Exercices

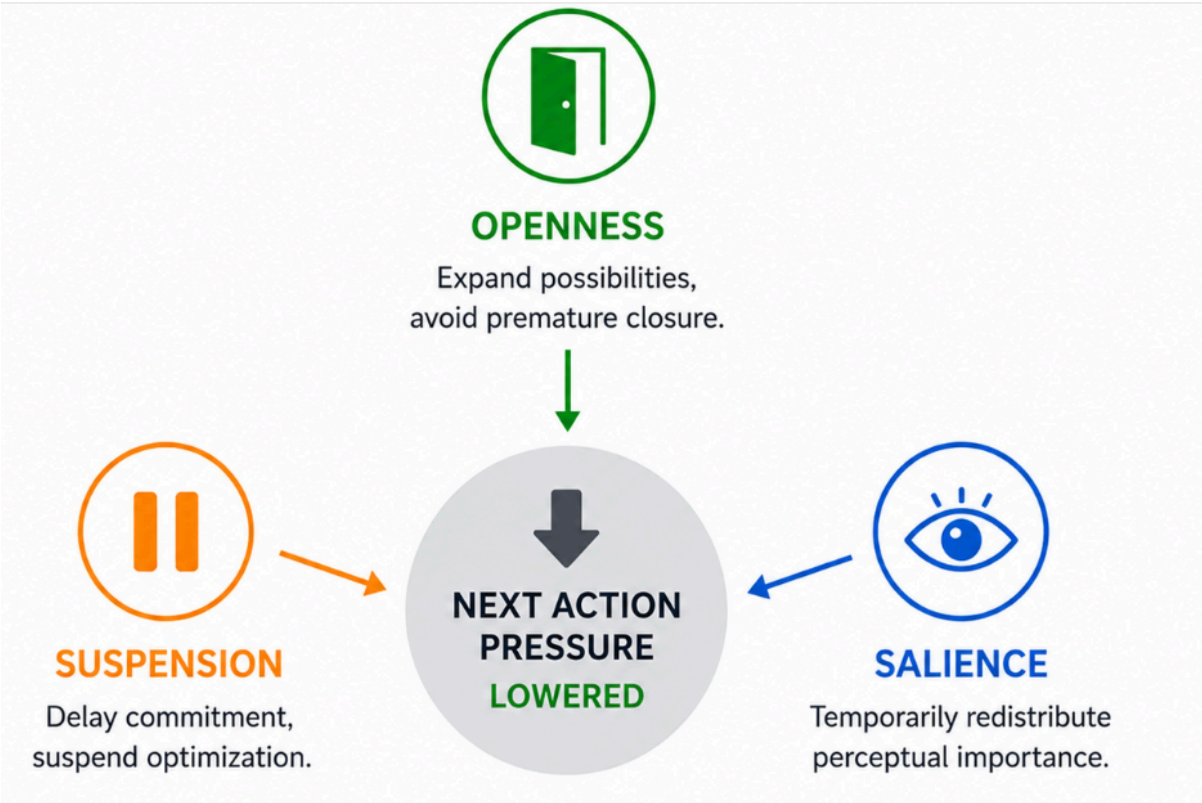

Figure 1. Openness, suspension, and salience exercises all reduce next-action pressure through complementary mechanisms, creating conditions more compatible with the emergence of joy.